

Moving in together to see if you're right for each other

8 findings · 15-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Moving in to find out raises the cost of leaving before you have your answer, whichever way the relationship is going. Living together is **easy to misread** as an agreement neither of you has actually made.

THE GOAL

You're getting an honest answer about where this is heading while you can still act on it. Name your own real reason for wanting to move in, out loud, first.

CHECKLIST

Sitting down with your partner to talk about moving in together, before either of you has agreed to it.

- ☐ Name your own real reason for wanting to move in, out loud, before your partner answers.
- ☐ Ask your partner to name their own reason too, before you compare notes.
- ☐ Say honestly which is true for each of you: more time together, testing the relationship, or a practical reason like the lease or money.
- ☐ If it's mainly wanting more time together, say so, then ask what you're each hoping this turns into.
- ☐ If either of you named testing the relationship, say so and agree to wait: date longer, or take a class first.
- ☐ If it's mainly practical, say so, then still ask what you're each hoping this turns into.
- ☐ Ask directly: "Where do you see this going?" and wait for a real answer, not a joke or a shrug.
- ☐ If your partner's answer about where this is heading is vague or noncommittal, name that instead of letting it pass.
- ☐ If marriage is part of the plan, **say plainly** whether you're both calling this a clear, mutual commitment before moving in.
- ☐ Once you're both ready, say yes to each other out loud, on a specific day, instead of letting a deadline decide for you.
- ☐ Tell one or two people close to you, together, that you've decided this and what it means.
- ☐ Write down the date and what you agreed, somewhere you'll both see it again.
- ☐ Say out loud **what happens to the place** and who moves out if it doesn't work, while it's still easy to talk about.
- ☐ If you realize you already live together without ever deciding, say so now and agree, out loud, to choose it going forward.
- ☐ If you already live together without ever deciding, also pick a relationship class or counselor to book together this month.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Moving in together raises the **cost of leaving**. That holds however the relationship is going.
- 2 Couples who'd already slid into living together, then took a **relationship class together**, avoided a divorce risk that only showed up for couples who skipped it.
- 3 Living together privately is a signal that's easy to misread, right up until you assume you're both equally committed.

What changes the odds

KNOW

Moving in together raises the **cost of leaving**. That holds however the relationship is going.

It's what researchers call inertia: shared living arrangements create switching costs that make leaving harder, no matter how the relationship is actually going. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Waiting until you're engaged, or otherwise clearly committed, removes the added risk of moving in before marriage.

The timing of a clear, mutual commitment matters more than simply living together first. [Source 5](#)

DO

Couples who'd already slid into living together, then took a **relationship class together**, avoided a divorce risk that only showed up for couples who skipped it.

A relationship class is a specific, doable step to take now, whatever already happened. [Source 6](#)

Why your reason for moving in matters

KNOW

Wanting to test the relationship, as your main reason to move in, is linked to feeling stuck with doubts once you're sharing a lease. Researchers say that's often because the doubts were already there.

Moving in then makes it harder to act on those doubts, not easier. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Moving in mainly because it makes financial sense, like a lease running out, goes with a bigger divorce risk than moving in to test the relationship.

Married couples surveyed who'd moved in mainly for money ended up divorced more often than those who'd moved in to test the relationship. [Source 7](#)

How to decide, instead of drifting

KNOW

Sliding into living together usually meant a **higher divorce rate** than deciding together on purpose.

Thirteen points sounds decisive, but about half of that traces to who the couples already were, not the choice itself. [Source 3](#)

SAY

Ask "Where do you see this going?" before you move in.

Logistics-only talk skips the part that matters: what you both intend for the future together. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

Living together privately is a signal that's easy to misread, right up until you assume you're both equally committed.

Announcing your commitment to people who'll remember makes you less likely to misread each other than a private, unannounced arrangement. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Living together before marriage is basically a risk-free trial run that proves whether you're compatible.

ACTUALLY

Virtually **no evidence** shows that living together first improves your odds. Moving in specifically to test things, the whole point of a trial run, is the reason linked to a rockier outcome. [Source 3](#)

Sources

1. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12636531/>
2. <https://ifstudies.org/blog/premarital-cohabitation-is-still-associated-with-greater-odds-of-divorce>

3. <https://ifstudies.org/report-brief/whats-the-plan-cohabitation-engagement-and-divorce>
4. <https://www.du.edu/news/new-du-study-highlights-risks-living-together-engagement>
5. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5956907/>
6. https://digitalcommons.du.edu/psychology_faculty/31/
7. <https://www.deseret.com/2023/5/1/23697802/living-together-cohabitation-before-marriage-linked-divorce/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Moving in together at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)